Case Study: Phishing Attack on a College Student

Phishing is a form of cybercrime where attackers attempt to force a user to divulge sensitive data, including passwords, banking or personal data, through impersonation of a trusted party. It typically takes the form of counterfeit emails, messages or sites that seem authentic.

A typical case is when a college student is sent an e-mail indicating she is being offered paid internship by a reputable firm. The email is very professional and it makes the student feel urgent as it says he has been shortlisted and he has only a short period to apply. It contains a link that takes one to a forged site that appears real.

The attack can happen in the following way, step-by-step: the attacker sends a believable email. Second, the victim clicks on the link with no verification of the sender. Third, the counterfeit site requests personal information including name, email and log-in password. Lastly, the attacker gathers this data and uses it to gain unauthorized or engage in financial fraud.

They often target students as they actively seek opportunities and can make a response without checking. The aftermath is stolen accounts, money loss, identity theft and personal data abuse.

This case points out that basic awareness alone is not sufficient unless the users use it with caution. To remain safe on the Internet, it is important to check sources and not to use suspicious links.